

Three Eras Compared

Quiz Study Guide

MUS/AAS 262 — Jazz History: Many Sounds, Many Voices

Early Jazz · Big Bands & Swing · Bebop

The One-Sentence Distinction

- **Week 1: Early Jazz (1900–1928)** — Jazz is *born*: small groups improvise *together* in New Orleans.
- **Week 2: Big Bands & Swing (1925–1945)** — Jazz goes *mainstream*: large orchestras make America *dance*.
- **Week 3: Bebop (1940–1950)** — Jazz becomes *art*: small combos play fast, complex music you *listen* to, not dance to.

Side-by-Side Comparison

	Early Jazz	Swing / Big Bands	Bebop
Dates	1900–1928	1925–1945	1940–1950
Birthplace	New Orleans	Harlem (Cotton Club), Kansas City	Harlem (Minton's Playhouse, Clark Monroe's)
Ensemble size	Small group (5–7)	Big band (15 pieces)	Small combo (4–6)
Core instruments	Trumpet/cornet, clarinet, trombone	3 trumpets, 3 trombones, 5 saxes, 4 rhythm	Trumpet/sax, piano, bass, drums
Dominant wind	Clarinet & trumpet	Saxophone replaces clarinet	Alto sax (Parker), trumpet (Dizzy)
Improvisation	Collective (heterophony) — everyone at once	Solos within arranged frameworks	Extended virtuosic solos over complex chord changes
Tempo	Moderate	Moderate, danceable	Very fast (or very slow ballads)
Rhythm feel	Swing rhythm emerging; beats 2 & 4	Four-on-the-floor (bass drum/hi-hat); smooth swing	Drummer on ride cymbal; pushing forward on beat

	Early Jazz	Swing / Big Bands	Bebop
Purpose	Community music, funerals, dances	Dance music — jazz IS pop music	Art music / listening — deliberately NOT for dancing
Audience	Local New Orleans	Mass national audience (radio, film)	Small insider audience; counterculture
Harmonic complexity	Blues scale, simple harmonies	32-bar AABA standards, rhythm changes	Upper extensions (9ths, 11ths, 13ths); “playing the changes”
Key forms	12-bar blues (A,A,B); ragtime multi-strain	32-bar AABA; 12-bar blues; contrafacts	Contrafacts over rhythm changes; 12-bar blues at extreme speed
Composition vs. improv	Moving from composed (ragtime) toward improvised	Elaborate arrangements (Ellington) vs. head arrangements (Basie)	Minimal arrangement; pre-composed head then extended improv
Cultural tension	Black innovation, white profit (ODJB)	“King of Swing” = white man (Goodman); Cotton Club segregation	WWII anger; Langston Hughes: “bee-bop” = police violence
Key concept	Heterophony, Congo Square, blues codification	Ellington effect, riffs, hot vs. cool, contrafact	Playing the changes, upper extensions, stride piano, walking bass

What Each Era Uniquely Contributes

Week 1: Early Jazz

1. **Invented the genre** — fused African rhythm, blues, ragtime, European harmony
2. **Collective improvisation** — nobody plays the same line (heterophony)
3. **Armstrong’s revolution** — shifted jazz from ensemble to soloist’s art; invented scat singing
4. **Codified the blues** — 12-bar A,A,B structure became foundational
5. **First recordings** — spread jazz beyond New Orleans

Week 2: Swing

1. **Big band format** — Fletcher Henderson’s 15-piece template still used today
2. **Jazz = America’s popular music** — people danced to it (Lindy Hop)
3. **Saxophone rises** — overtook clarinet as dominant jazz wind instrument

4. **Compositional sophistication** — Ellington elevated jazz to art-music composition
5. **Star soloists from ensembles** — Hawkins, Young, Webster, Hodges
6. **Contrafact tradition** — writing new melodies over existing chord progressions

Week 3: Bebop

1. **Small group revolution** — WWII economics killed big bands; combos took over
2. **Virtuosic improvisation** — extreme speed, complex harmonic navigation
3. **Art music, not dance music** — deliberate rejection of entertainment model
4. **Harmonic expansion** — upper extensions (9ths, 11ths, 13ths)
5. **All 12 keys** — Parker made this standard for jazz musicians
6. **Counterculture identity** — zoot suits, berets, goatees, horn-rimmed glasses

Key Artists by Era

Week 1: Early Jazz

Artist	Nickname/Title	Remember By
Scott Joplin	“King of Ragtime”	Solo piano, NO improv, syncopated “oom-pah” — the <i>pre-cursor</i> , not jazz itself
W.C. Handy	“Father of the Blues”	First to <i>write down</i> blues; tango/“Spanish tinge” in St. Louis Blues
ODJB	—	First jazz <i>recording</i> (1917); all-white band; Keppard refused first
Bessie Smith	“Empress of the Blues”	Voice bending/sliding into notes; instrumentalists copied <i>her</i>
Jelly Roll Morton	Creole; “invented jazz”	Spoken dialogue intro; funeral march; Red Hot Peppers; composer/arranger
Louis Armstrong	“First Great Soloist”	Unaccompanied trumpet cadenza; vibrato at END of notes; scat singing; Hot Five/Seven

Week 2: Swing

Artist	Nickname/Title	Remember By
Duke Ellington	—	Composer-bandleader; “Ellington effect”; jungle style; Cotton Club; 50-year band
Billy Strayhorn	Ellington’s collaborator	Wrote “Take the A Train” (NOT Ellington); coined “Ellington effect”
Count Basie	—	Minimalist piano; riffs; head arrangements; Kansas City; All-American Rhythm Section
Fletcher Henderson	—	Invented the 15-piece big band format (~1924)
Coleman Hawkins	“Hawk” / “Bean” / “Father of Jazz Tenor Sax”	HOT, vertical improv (arpeggios up/down chord tones); heavy vibrato
Lester Young	“Prez” (from Holiday)	COOL, horizontal improv (melodic lines across chords); minimal vibrato
Ben Webster	(Big Three tenor)	Hot/breathy sound; Ellington’s band
Benny Goodman	“King of Swing”	White clarinetist; integrated his band; Gene Krupa on drums
Billie Holiday	“Lady Day” (from Young)	Voice like an instrument/horn; fragile timbre; legato phrasing
Ella Fitzgerald	“First Lady of Song”	Four-octave range; master of scat singing
Papa Joe Jones	(Basie’s drummer)	Moved four-on-the-floor from bass drum to hi-hat — influenced bebop

Week 3: Bebop

Artist	Nickname/Title	Remember By
Charlie Parker	“Bird” / “everyone’s God”	Heart and soul of bebop; alto sax; upper extensions; all 12 keys; heroin addiction
Dizzy Gillespie	“Dizzy”	Public face of bebop; bullfrog cheeks; upturned trumpet; very high register; jovial
Bud Powell	—	Bebop pianist; right hand = horn-like lines, left hand = sparse comping (not stride)
Roy Eldridge	—	Bridge between Armstrong and Dizzy; hot trumpet sound
Charlie Christian	—	First electric guitar in jazz; died at 25; long flowing melodic lines
Art Tatum	—	Legally blind; incredible technique; stride piano; influenced Bud Powell
Jimmy Blanton	—	Walking bass; died at 23; Ellington’s band; huge resonant sound
Kenny Clarke	—	First bebop drummer; drums drive the beat like guitar
Max Roach	—	Featured bebop drummer on Parker’s “Ko Ko”

Listening Song-to-Era Cheat Sheet

Use this to instantly place any song in its era. The **Instant ID Cue** tells you what to listen for.

Week 1 — Early Jazz (1900–1928)

If it sounds old, scratchy, small group, collective improv, or stiff/ragtime-ish, it's Week 1.

Song	Artist	Year	Instant ID Cue
"Maple Leaf Rag"	Scott Joplin	1916	Solo piano, mechanical, no swing, no improv — ragtime precursor
"St. Louis Blues"	W.C. Handy	1922	Tango rhythm in the middle (Spanish tinge); composed; muted trumpet
"Dixie Jass Band One-Step"	ODJB	1917	Marching band feel , stiff/military, no real soloists — earliest jazz recording
"Backwater Blues"	Bessie Smith	1927	Just voice + piano ; vocal bending/sliding; dual call-and-response
"Dead Man Blues"	Jelly Roll Morton	1926	Spoken dialogue intro , then funeral march; Red Hot Peppers
"West End Blues"	Louis Armstrong	1928	Unaccompanied trumpet cadenza opening — most famous moment in early jazz

Week 2 — Swing / Big Bands (1925–1945)

If it sounds like a large orchestra with sections (brass vs. reeds), danceable, polished, it's Week 2.

Song	Artist	Year	Instant ID Cue
"Take the A Train"	Ellington (Stray-horn)	1941	Catchy trumpet melody ; Ellington effect underneath; full big band
"Cottontail"	Ellington	1940	Ben Webster's hot tenor sax solo ; contrafact on "I Got Rhythm"
"One O'Clock Jump"	Count Basie	1937	Melody at the end (head arrangement); sparse piano; hi-hat timekeeping
"Oh! Lady Be Good"	Basie / Young	1936	Lester Young's cool, airy, relaxed tenor sax — opposite of Hawkins
"Body and Soul"	Coleman Hawkins	1939	Almost entirely improvised ; melody barely stated; vertical; heavy vibrato; lush
"Sing, Sing, Sing"	Benny Goodman	1937	Gene Krupa's driving tom-tom drum pattern ; 7+ minutes; clarinet solo
"God Bless the Child"	Billie Holiday	1942	Fragile, horn-like voice ; legato phrasing; words spill together; yearning
"Blue Skies"	Ella Fitzgerald	1958	Scat singing showcase ; four-octave range; virtuosic vocal improv

Week 3 — Bebop (1940–1950)

If it's blindingly fast, small combo, angular melodies, ride cymbal, and you can't dance to it, it's Week 3.

Song	Artist	Year	Instant ID Cue
"Dizzy Atmosphere"	Parker & Gillespie	Live	Extremely fast ; alto sax + trumpet; rhythm changes; Dizzy's high register
"Ko Ko"	Charlie Parker	1945	Pre-composed intro/outro ; virtuosic solo at breakneck speed; Max Roach; Miles on piano
"Parker's Mood"	Charlie Parker	1948	The exception : slow tempo, bluesy, emotional — proves Parker isn't just about speed
"Tempus Fugue-it"	Bud Powell	1940s	Piano trio ; right hand plays fast horn-like lines; left hand sparse comping (NOT stride)

Quick-Fire Differentiation Tricks

How to Tell the Eras Apart by SOUND Alone

1. **Can you dance to it?** Yes = Swing. No and it's fast = Bebop. Somewhere in between = Early Jazz.
2. **How big is the band?** Full orchestra with sections = Swing. Small combo = Early Jazz or Bebop. Distinguish by speed/complexity.
3. **Is everyone improvising at once?** Yes = Early Jazz (heterophony). One soloist over arranged backgrounds = Swing. One soloist blazing over rhythm section = Bebop.
4. **How fast and complex?** Moderate and bluesy = Early Jazz. Smooth and danceable = Swing. Blazing fast with angular leaps = Bebop.
5. **What does the drummer do?** Marching-band-ish = Early Jazz. Four-on-the-floor bass drum or hi-hat = Swing. Ride cymbal with "bombs" = Bebop.

How to Tell the Eras Apart by PHILOSOPHY

- **Early Jazz**: "Let's all play together and have a good time"
- **Swing**: "Let's entertain the whole country and get people dancing"
- **Bebop**: "This is serious art — if you can't keep up, that's your problem"

The Throughline of Improvisation

- **Early Jazz**: Collective improv (everyone at once) → Armstrong begins solo improv

- **Swing**: Extended solos within arranged frameworks; hot (Hawkins) vs. cool (Young)
- **Bebop**: Virtuoso solo improv over complex chord changes is the entire point

The Throughline of the Saxophone

- **Early Jazz**: Clarinet is the main wind (sax barely present)
- **Swing**: Saxophone overtakes clarinet; Big Three tenors emerge (Hawkins, Young, Webster)
- **Bebop**: Alto sax (Parker) is king; the instrument that defines the era